

Doorstep Deliberation

Pre-Analysis Plan

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Abstract

This is the pre-analysis plan for a doorstep experiment testing the effects of deliberative interactions on diffuse and specific supports. In cooperation with a political party, the experiment randomises whether doorstep interactions are deliberative or non-deliberative. In the non-deliberative condition, canvassers listen to voters' concerns and use active listening strategies after which they pitch the party's policy position on a given issue. In the deliberative condition, they additionally discuss this issue with the voter, put forward their own arguments for the party's position and respond to counterarguments. At the end of the conversation, voters are handed a physical mini-questionnaire measuring propensity to vote for the party, evaluation of party responsiveness, coalition preference, and liking of the interaction. I cross-randomise whether outcomes are measured anonymously and via a small ballot box or through the canvasser asking face-to-face to gauge social desirability bias. Deliberative interactions are expected to increase PTV, evaluations of party responsiveness, and liking of the interaction. They are also expected to improve the accuracy of canvassers' PTV guesses. Mode is expected to shift levels of the DV but not the treatment effect.

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Table of contents

Theoretical Background	1
Campaign Study Perspective	1
Representation Perspective	1
Dependent Variables	1
Compliance and Survey Flow	2

Theoretical Background

- Reflexivity is what improves representation. Deliberation is a tool to improve reflexivity. Therefore, deliberation should improve representation.
- We know that deliberation reduces polarisation and can lead to attitude change.

Campaign Study Perspective

- Are longer conversations more effective than shorter conversations? Is it worth investing in more meaningful conversations at the doorstep?
- Do deliberative conversations lead to more positive evaluations of the party and a higher PTV to vote for it?

Representation Perspective

Dependent Variables

Which dependent variables are measured depends partly on the measurement mode. For an overview of the main dependent variables, see the Table 1.

Table 1: Dependent Variables Collected from Respondent

Variable Label	Question Text	Response Scale	Mode	Respondent
PTV	“How likely are you to vote for [party] in the next election?”	1-5 scale	Both	Voter
Party responsiveness	“What would you say, to what extent do the Greens care about the opinions of people like you?”	1-5 scale	both	Voter
Coalition Preference	“Which coalition would you prefer to govern Berlin after the next election?”	1-5 scale	both	Voter
Liking	“How did you like this conversation?”	1-5 scale	anonymous only	Voter

In addition to the dependent variables collected from voters, canvassers collect some additional variables and guess voters responses to the PTV question. For an overview of these variables, see Table 2.

Table 2: Dependent Variables Collected from Canvasser

Variable Label	Question Text	Response Scale	Mode	Respondent
Liking	“How did you like this conversation?”	1-5 scale	Both	Canvasser
Topics	“Which topics did the voter mention”	Item battery	Both	Canvasser
Duration	NA	Timer	Both	Canvasser
PTV guess	What do you think, how likely is the person you just talked to vote for [party] in the Berlin elections?	Timer	Both	Canvasser

Compliance and Survey Flow

- What’s an NA?
- Door open vs. conversation happened